

The Dragon Curse

This tale is inspired by the Norse myth of Nidhogg the dragon and Yggdrasil, the Tree of Life.

I am Nidhogg! Dragon of the deep. Ruler of the underworld!" Nidhogg threw the bones he had been gnawing far and wide. They clattered and shattered on rocks, splintering into shards that pierced deep into the gnarled roots of the oldest tree in the universe. The tree shook in agony, causing earthquakes, volcanoes, and tsunamis to erupt in the nine worlds it held in its roots.

Nidhogg watched the destruction with glee, and licked his lips as bodies tumbled between the roots and piled up at his clawed feet. "Supper!" Nidhogg cried.

As he finished the banquet of bodies before him, day turned to night. The Gods, way up above, lit the stars and called the oceans and seas to return and rest in the moonlight. But for Nidhogg, trapped in the underworld, there was only darkness.

Nidhogg stared into a gap in the trunk of the tree and watched the Gods walking the rainbow paths between the worlds, free to go wherever they wished. A ball of burning fury grew inside him, until the heat rivaled the power of the sun. In a huge flash, flames shot from his flaring nostrils.

"I am the God of all beasts! I should leap between worlds, rule all things, call up storms, and power the tides!" Nidhogg roared.

"Why am I in the dark? I should be closer to heaven, where I will rule all the worlds."

Nidhogg snarled to summon his squirrel messenger down the tree. The squirrel shot down, twisting and turning around the trunk, in and out of the nine worlds. Puffing and panting, he reached Nidhogg in the underworld.

"What took you so long?" Nidhogg demanded. **"This message cannot wait!"**

"Tell the Gods that if I am not freed from this dark prison, I will gnaw on the roots of this tree until it dies, then slither up its trunk and bring eternal winter to all of the worlds. The very breath in every being's lungs will freeze, and they will become ice statues forever."

The squirrel saw the fury in Nidhogg's blazing eyes and shot back up the trunk, weaving in and out of the nine worlds, past humans and elves and giants and sprites, to the very top of the tree. The squirrel leapt up onto the shoulder of the God of all the Gods and whispered the message.

The God of all the Gods took a deep breath and thought hard before replying. "Please remind Nidhogg that he is imprisoned forever as

